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The Internet's Devolution

When net neutrality norms are flouted by big corporations the world over, it alters the very nature of the internet experienced by all of us

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As people using the internet are constantly adjusting and evolving to a digital lifestyle, so is the internet evolving as an entity based on our behaviour. And it's evident if you look back to the birth and the explosive growth of the internet to this very moment. In a not so distant future, most people won't remember how the Internet was once upon a time – free and beyond the control of spying governments or greedy corporations. Because it's such a powerful medium of our age – something that's altering human behaviour down to its very core – everyone's fighting to exert control over it. Not surprisingly, ISPs – our gateway to the internet – are becoming more demanding on how we

access the internet. Some of the decisions they take are having far-reaching implications, something that will span well beyond just your monthly internet bill.

Net Neutrality 101

The basic premise of Net Neutrality is that all data is to be treated equally. This means that your ISP (which happens to be the entity providing you with internet connection) will treat your request to access Flipkart.com, Google.com or ThePirateBay.se, Pastebin.com, or Mega.co.nz without distinction and on equal priority. The ISP won't play favourites when it comes to serving one site better than the other. We trust them to be neutral gatekeepers that let us access the internet for a fee, but in doing so they do not knowingly alter our experience of the internet in any way. These, along with other explicit points, form

the guiding principles of the FCC's (Federal Communications Commission) Open Internet policy (read more here: <http://dgit.in/FCCnet>) which was adopted back in 2010 in order to limit the power of ISPs to block or discriminate against online content.

What's at stake?

Earlier this year in January, a federal court in America ruled against the FCC's Open Internet rules and awarded Verizon (a major telecom operator and ISP in the US) to break free of FCC's regulations, which they argued (and the court agreed) only governs landline and mobile telephony and not this relatively new "information services" service known as the internet.

The reason why activists in the US and most of the West are up in arms, treating this landmark court verdict as a hammer blow to the freedom of the internet because